no-one was giving me an inch. When I asked Jackie if she'd get Tony to come and talk to me, she wasn't having any of it:

'No, David. You have to do it yourself.'

I eventually cornered the prospective father-in-law in the prospective brother-in-law's old room. I'd asked Tony if we could have a quick word in private and we trudged up the stairs together, me feeling like I was off to an execution. I walked into Christian's old bedroom and tripped on the leg of the bed and stubbed my toe. At least Tony was behind me and so he didn't see it happen. I looked at him. He looked at me. I wasn't doing too well on breathing, never mind getting the words out and the pain in my foot didn't help.

'Tony. I'm asking Victoria to marry me. Is that okay?'

Not the best speech a would-be son-in-law ever made. He answered as if I'd just asked him if egg and chips would be all right for tea:

'Yeah. No problem.'

I suppose I'd been getting wound up about it enough for both of us. I know how much Tony and Jackie love Victoria, so I realized his relaxed attitude about us getting engaged meant they'd decided I wasn't the worst sort in the world. In fact, they'd already made me feel part of the family: this was just the next step for us all. Maybe I could have saved myself from a potential heart attack by not posing the big question, but asking Tony—like going down on one knee to Victoria—wasn't just for show. I was only going to do these things once in my life, which meant they were incredibly important to me: I wanted to make sure I went about them the right way.

I'd like to say that it was because those were the months when I fell in love with Victoria and proposed to her that I don't remember much of United's season in 1997/98. The truth is, I've probably done my best to forget reaching that May and not having any kind of winners' medal to show for it. It was new to all of us, the generation who had grown up together during the 1990s. We'd won Youth Cups and Reserve leagues and then, when we stepped up to the United first team, we'd just carried on where we'd left off as kids. The season ended up being a painful one, learning what it felt like to lose. Suddenly, here were Arsenal, doing what we expected to do ourselves: winning the Double. Without wanting to be disrespectful about that Arsenal team, the disappointment didn't ever undermine our belief in ourselves. They won their games but at United we felt we lost the Premiership by not winning